

| By Farzand Ahmed |

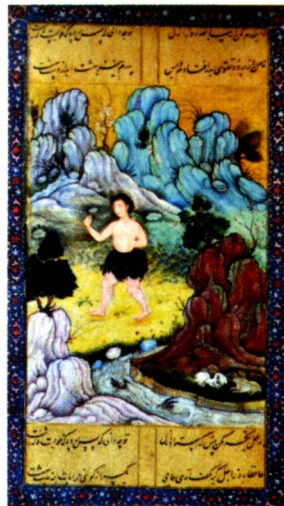
Most people gravitate to the national libraries in the main metros when they seek ancient Indian manuscripts and artifacts. What they really need to do is take a detour to some unusual destinations: the Rampur Raza Library in Uttar Pradesh's Rohillakhand and the Khuda Bakhsh Oriental Library in Patna, which are veritable treasure troves of Indo-Islamic literature, Arabic calligraphy and medieval art. Together, they host 38,000 rare ancient and medieval manuscripts, including calligraphed Korans in gold and a *Ramayana* in Persian. The assortment includes over 7,000 paintings, 3.35 lakh books in various languages and a medley of antiques and artifacts. During Ramzan in September, the libraries exhibited their priceless collections, providing a rare insight into Indo-Islamic art and literature in Arabic, Persian, Urdu and Sanskrit as well the written art form of calligraphy.

The Rampur Raza library proudly preserves a Koran in the old Arabic Kufi script on parchment. It was written by Hazrat Ali, the fourth Caliph of Islam (A.D. 661). Patna's Khuda Bakhsh Library has a Koran written by Hazrat Ali's father Abu Talib (Prophet Mohammad's uncle) on a deer skin. It also flaunts a rare, inch-wide Koran and the *Jehangir-Nama*, the autobiography of Emperor Jehangir; *Tarikh-i-Khandan-i-Timuriya*, the history of the house of Taimur by Emperor Akbar; *Kitab-al-Hashaish*, a revised Arabic version by Hunayn bin Ishaq of the Greek original dictionary of medicine, and *Al-Lumafi al-Tasawwuf*, a rare book on Islamic mysticism. They are housed under high security along with the *Diwan-i-Hafiz*, which contains 500 ghazals and 42 Rubaiyyes from the collections of Mughal Emperors Humayun and Jehangir. The *Kitab-Al-Tasrif* describes surgical methods and instruments with illustrations.

The repository also has a huge col-

Hidden TREASURES

Two little-known libraries preserve a rare collection of Indo-Islamic literature, art and Arabic calligraphy



lection of over 18,000 Arabic and Persian manuscripts and over 2,000 rare paintings from the Mughal and Rajput eras. It is known for its extraordinary collection of over 21,000 manuscripts in Arabic, Pali, Pashtu, Persian, Sanskrit, Turkish and Urdu, some of them extremely rare and richly illustrated in gold and also for its Mughal, Iranian, Central Asian and

Rajput paintings. Khuda Bakhsh Library's director Imtiaz Ahmad, an authority on medieval Indian history, says that the library has become a centre of research for scholars of Islamic studies and medieval Indian history; west, south and central Asian studies; Mughal architecture; Islamic sciences and Mughal, Iranian, Central Asian and Rajput paintings. It also

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